Individual 2 - Mitch

Interview:

The interview was conducted with a 4th year Computer Science and Economics major in the HSSC. We started on the south side to see their room selection process and an interview was conducted afterwards.

Q1: What is your usual process to find a room to study?
“Usually I am in the HSSC. I start on the first floor of the north tower, walk toward the south side, go up the stairs, check the stairs, check the south side of the second floor, cross to the north, go up again, check the third floor, then head to the south tower. Kind of a snake pattern.

Observation: Described instantly and traced in air. A fixed habit. The search is entirely physical usually unless someone already has a room that is his friend.
Q2: Does finding a room increase your productivity?
“No. Finding a room is a distraction. It takes time out of work and my day. I wish there was a better way or it was less busy.”

Observation: They separate having a good room from finding one. Answered quickly and volunteered the frustration unprompted.
Q3. Do you ever fail to find a room, especially in your favorite building?
"Yes. Before exams it can take 10 to 20 minutes of walking around and I still find nothing, so I go to the library reading room instead. Worst times are midterms and finals. On regular weekdays, classes run until about 4, and then 7 to 11 p.m. is difficult once athletes are done with practice and dinner: Monday through Thursday."

Observation: Two failure windows: the exam calendar and weekday evenings. The 10–20 minute wasted walk is the core problem to solve.
Q4: What is your favorite academic building?
"The library these days — I feel more inclined to work there. Then HSSC. CLS is good for grad school and fellowship applications. I don't study in noisy spaces unless a group meeting requires it."

Observation: Their favorite study building and their search building differ. They hunt in HSSC because that's where rooms are, then retreat to the library when it fails.
Q5: Would you benefit from an app that tracks which rooms are taken?
"Oh yeah, for sure — as long as students take responsibility for marking when they occupy a room."

Observation: Immediate yes, but they flagged the adoption dependency themselves before we raised it.

Q6: Do you get frustrated with how busy the gym or dining hall is?
"Not frustrated. It makes sense that it's busy at lunch. With the gym, maybe annoyed. But I already know the busy times for both. Classrooms are always a gamble."

Observation: Key distinction. Predictable crowding vs. unpredictable. "A gamble" is the sharpest summary of the real pain point.

Q7: Would you want the app to track gym and dining hall
"I think that's a given. I don't think that would be necessary."

Observation: Clear no. This feature should be dropped or deprioritized in this context; it adds nothing to a mental model they already have.

Q8: Would you log the rooms you use, for example for a week, to gather data and prove that this system works?
"I'd prefer a scanner. If the room has a QR code and I just scan it, then yes — that doesn't require much time from me."

Observation: They reframed rather than answered. No to manual logging, yes to scanning. The limit is effort, not willingness.

Q9: Would you scan a QR code outside each room?
"Yes. I thought about saying how long I'd be there, but I don't really need that. The issue is students will forget to log out, so the room stays marked as taken when it's empty. You could also ask the administration for permission to put the codes up."

Observation: The most valuable answer in the interview. They identified the stale-data flaw and the institutional dependency without prompting.

Q10: Do you prefer the (hssc) atrium over a room?
"No. I don't study in noisy spaces. If I'm in an open area it's because a group meeting put me there."

Observation: When the search fails they leave the building entirely rather than settle for open seating, so a failed search costs more than just the walk.

Q11: Do you prefer studying alone or with others?
"I want my own private space. I'll study with a group when it's required, but otherwise not."

Observation: Strongly solo. "A room" means a small, closeable space, not a six-person group room.

Persona: Busy and Booked CS/ECN Double Major Warrior

Name: Kurt
Sex: Male
Age: 21
Grinnell College Student
Computer Science and Economics Major

Important Characteristics: Always stressed, always doing something to further their athletic, intellectual, or social skills. Doesn't sit still and doesn't like to waste time.
Current Solution: Ask friends if they have a study space or do the snake method in the HSSC.
Wants: To use their time as wisely as possible. Have a planned place to sit and study without the hassle. Wants to go to bed at a reasonable time despite their piling up work due to procrastination and heavy partying on the weekends.
Needs: Gym, Eating at the Dining Hall,
Avoids: Excessive social interactions, loud areas, cramped rooms, badly lit rooms, the atrium, busy dining hall, busy gym.

The Busy and Booked CS/ECN Double Major Warrior always seeks the following question when looking for a place to study: Where can I study with good lighting, good chairs, and quiet/distraction free, and how can I find that room quickly in order to not waste time in my busy day.

Brainstorming:

SCAMPER Method

1. Substitute
    - Use registrars class schedule as a baseline
2. Combine
    - Combine with a map of the building's floor plan
3. Adapt
    - Adapt Google Maps' "popular times prediction"
4. Modify/minify/magnify
    - Minify the idea to one building and one floor for the pilot idea
5. Put to another use
    - Repurpose to new 25live system for event and club room booking
6. Eliminate
    - Cut gym and dining hall entirely based off the interview
7. Reverse
    - Instead of marking rooms as taken, mark them as free when they leave.